

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 57

By Howell

A RESOLUTION to honor and congratulate Jessie Lee Coppock on the celebration of her 104th birthday.

WHEREAS, it is fitting that we pay tribute to those citizens who are celebrating special occasions in their estimable lives; and

WHEREAS, Jessie Lee Coppock will celebrate her 104th birthday on March 7, 2025, a milestone that will be commemorated as yet another precious souvenir of life's rich pageant; and

WHEREAS, Ms. Coppock was born on March 7, 1921, in Crawford County, and she has enjoyed an amazing life and experienced firsthand the breadth and span of American history; and

WHEREAS, the second of thirteen children born to Robert Lee Gulledge and Olvie Elizabeth Harris Gulledge, Jessie Coppock relocated with her family to Conasauga in Polk County, where her father sought employment and worked as a sharecropper and in sawmills to make ends meet; and

WHEREAS, Ms. Coppock has recalled many of the hardships her family endured in order to survive, such as eating cornmeal gravy made with water until the wheat grain was ready for harvest and saving eggs to trade for coffee and other necessary items from the rolling store, which came by once a week; and

WHEREAS, her family often crossed a frozen Conasauga River by wagon in the wintertime and walked when road conditions became too muddy for the wagon wheels; she also went to school in a covered wagon, taking her milk in an old vanilla flavoring bottle and carrying her food in a metal bucket; and

WHEREAS, Jessie Coppock and her family stored vegetables underground to prevent them from freezing and made what was known as "leather britches," green beans strung up with thread to dry; at times, breakfast consisted of only cooked corn, but her father ensured they never went to bed hungry; and

WHEREAS, the children normally helped with housework, among other farming jobs, including cutting sugarcane and loading the wagon; washing laundry by the river and hanging the clothes on shrubs to dry; and picking cotton and loading it into the gin, a job that proved to be quite dangerous, if they were not careful; and

WHEREAS, Ms. Coppock would help her mother make lye soap from fireplace ashes, can green beans by boiling them in the wash tub, salt and sugar cure the hog meat, and milk the cows to clabber and churn buttermilk and butter; and

WHEREAS, at the age of six, Jessie Coppock was required to walk a quarter mile to the barn to feed and harness the mules for work in the fields; she would then return home and prepare breakfast alongside her older sister, using homemade stools to reach the top of the wood stove; and

WHEREAS, despite many hardships, Ms. Coppock, her family, and other neighborhood children found joy in the small things and always made time to play and enjoy one another's company; after the Conasauga River Bridge was completed, Conasauga residents gathered at the edge of the bridge to celebrate, with people praying, singing songs, and worshipping; and

WHEREAS, as Jessie Coppock enters her 104th year, she is truly revered for her perseverance and her dedication to her family and faith; and

WHEREAS, we wish to grasp this golden opportunity to specially recognize one of Tennessee's most outstanding citizens on this very special occasion; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE

CONCURRING, that we recognize and honor Jessie Lee Coppock on the celebration of her 104th birthday and extend to her our best wishes for many happy returns of the day.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.